The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

From the sweet by-and-by back to the nasty now-and-now: rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in everything — the will of God for an ordinary week.

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Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 **An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church**	**02** 1:6–10 **The Many Faces of the Gospel**	**03** 2:1–12 **Delivering the Gospel**	**04** 2:13–20 **A Successful Life of Service**	**05** 3:1–13 **Facing Tribulation**
06 4:1–12 **A Life That Pleases God**	**07** 4:13–18 **The Rapture of the Church**	**08** 5:1–11 **The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope**	**09** 5:12–22 **The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations**	**10** 5:23–28 **'Til We Meet Again**

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

Three sets of instructions

1 Thessalonians 5:12–22 · Outline I–III

To those who are led · 12–13

- Recognize your leaders
- Esteem them very highly in love
- Be at peace among yourselves

To those who lead · 14–15

- Warn, comfort, uphold, be patient
- Never evil for evil
- Always pursue the good

To the whole church · 16–22

- Rejoice · pray · give thanks
- Don’t quench the Spirit or despise prophecy
- Test · hold fast · abstain

The coming of the Lord thrills our souls. Obeying the Lord fills our souls. These exhortations are the proof of whether we believe what we have heard.

Marks of a good leader

1 Thessalonians 5:12–13 · I.A–C — Instructions to those who are led

They toil
κοπιάω kopiaō · G2872

- Hard work to the point of weariness
- A full day's job — then the church

They take charge
προΐστημι proistēmi · G4291

- They "stand before you"
- Good leaders don't hide — they lead from out front

They train
"in the Lord" in a truly Christian way

- Training the people to do the work of the Lord

Esteem them very highly (ἡγέομαι) — in agapē love, for their work's sake. You don't have to like the way a pastor combs his hair. Not personality — faithfulness. And "be at peace": maintain the peace you already have.

Four people, four responses

1 Thessalonians 5:14 · II.A — Help these people

A — Warn the disorderly

ἄτακτος — broke rank: idle, waiting for the Lord (2 Thess 3:6–8)

B — Comfort the fainthearted

ὀλιγόψυχος — the little-souled: grief, fear, intimidation

C — Uphold the weak

Morally or spiritually weak — bear them up, hold them steady

D — Be patient with all

Long-suffering — as patient as God has been with you

Warning the fainthearted would crush them; comforting the disorderly would enable them. Good leadership diagnoses before it responds.

Three levels of response

1 Thessalonians 5:15 · II.B — Hold these principles

A

Evil for evil

Human — natural instinct; it requires no grace

cut off in traffic

B

Evil for good

Devilish — someone does you good, you do them evil

never

C

Good for evil

Divine — where we must be, with anyone

heaps coals of fire

Prohibit this · Pursue this: “See that no one renders evil for evil to anyone, but always pursue what is good both for yourselves and for all.”

The will of God in Christ Jesus for you

1 Thessalonians 5:16–18 · III.A–C — Rejoice, pray, give thanks

Always praise · v.16
χαίρω rejoice · G5463

- Shortest verse in Greek — 14 letters
- Joy is the Christian's flag: the King is in residence

Without ceasing, pray · v.17
ἀδιαλείπτως without ceasing · G89

- Like a hacking cough — all through the day
- Stated times, like Daniel — and staying in touch

In all things, appreciate · v.18

- In everything — every circumstance
- Thank Him for what He has already done
- Even while praying for change

"For this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you." What is God's will for my life? Start there.

Say yes — and test everything

1 Thessalonians 5:19–22 · III.D–H

v.19	Do not quench the Spirit — say yes to God	**σβέννυμι** throwing water on a fire
v.20	Do not despise prophecies — checked by others (1 Cor 14:29)	— now: the completed Scriptures
v.21a	Test all things — by the written Word of God	**δοκιμάζω** put it to the fire of the Word
v.21b	Hold fast what is good — tested truth is the church's treasure	— grip it; don't let it slip
v.22	Abstain from every form of evil	**εἶδος** every form evil actually takes

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 5:12–22 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 14 addresses the disorderly, the fainthearted, the weak and those who are different. What does it tell us about pastoral ministry that one response doesn't fit all four?

2. Paul says rejoicing, praying and giving thanks are "the will of God in Christ Jesus for you." How does that change how you approach those three things?

Apply

Return Good for Evil, Every Time

Do one specific, unrequested good thing this week for someone who has wronged you — and tell no one.

Rejoice, Pray, Give Thanks

For seven days: one sentence of rejoicing, one minute of prayer, one expression of thanks each morning.

In one line: While we wait, we still live here: honor your leaders, care wisely for one another, return good for evil, and live God's stated will.